‘request’ from a US warship. ‘You cannot anticipate all the details of any operation,’ McNamara opined some years later.[92] True that. But it can be anticipated with some certainty that no Soviet warship would allow itself to be boarded by the US navy (whether in formal white dress uniform or wielding cutlases and flintlocks).

It almost defies credulity that McNamara’s assumptions were not challenged or scrutinised by military or civilian officials, including of course, the President. Nor, as will be seen later, did anyone ponder whether the Soviet submarines were carrying nuclear weapons, even though, according to Dino Brugioni, US naval intelligence believed the Project 641 could fire a nuclear torpedo.[93]

The Presidential Recordings indicate that Kennedy and ExComm only learned of the SSIPs on the morning of 24 October *after* the blockade had come into effect and *after* Moscow was told about the procedures. And it was only a matter of hours (so ExComm erroneously believed) before the US navy would be intercepting ships supported by submarines. The assumption that the Soviet submariners knew what the US navy intended was an unchallenged and potentially catastrophic assumption. Eat your heart out, Barbara Tuchman.

The meeting of ExComm on the morning of 24 October provides one of the most dramatic moments of the crisis, culminating in the famous remark of Dean Rusk. When it was realised that Soviet ships were stopping and/or turning round, the Secretary of State quipped: ‘We are eyeball to eyeball, and I think the other fellow just blinked.’[94] The phrase, he explained in his memoirs, ‘came from a childhood game we used to play in Georgia. Where we would stand about two feet apart and stare into each other’s eyes. Whoever blinked first lost the game.’ Curiously, the comment was not picked up by JFK’s microphones (though McGeorge Bundy made reference to it the following day). It, nevertheless, entered the public domain, much to Rusk’s anger at a leak from within the White House.[95] It soon became part of the lore of the crisis. Robert Kennedy recalled: ‘For a moment the world had stood still, and now it was going around again.’[96]

Michael Dobbs, however, explains in his 2007 book *One Minute to Midnight*,that the famous eyeball to eyeball moment was ‘largely